



Provenance research landscape Jan Vermeer van Haarlem I

provisional findings – version 4

2026

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Provenance Phase 1 – 1902

The painting by Jan Vermeer van Haarlem I was included in the auction catalogue of the Old Masters, Nineteenth Century & Early Modern Art auction which was held by auction house Venduehuis der Notarissen in The Hague on May 26th and May 27th 2026 and described as follows:

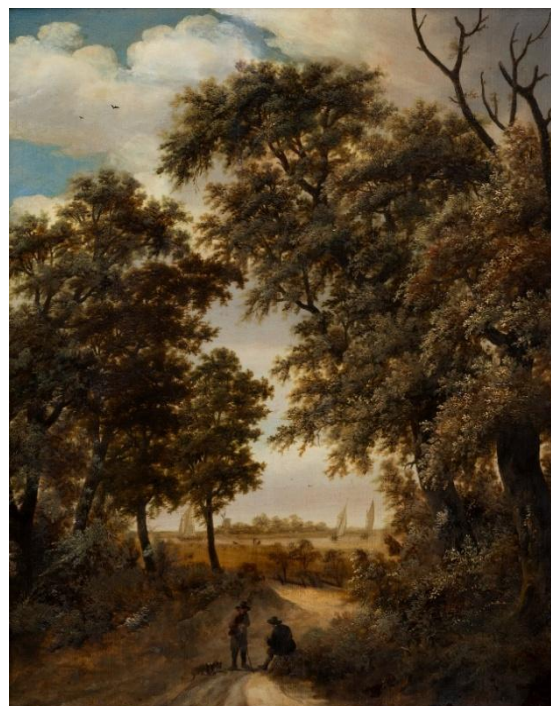
102. Jan Vermeer van Haarlem I (1628-1691). *Travellers on the road leading to the river, oil on panel, 55 x 45 cm. € 4,000 - € 6,000*

Literature:

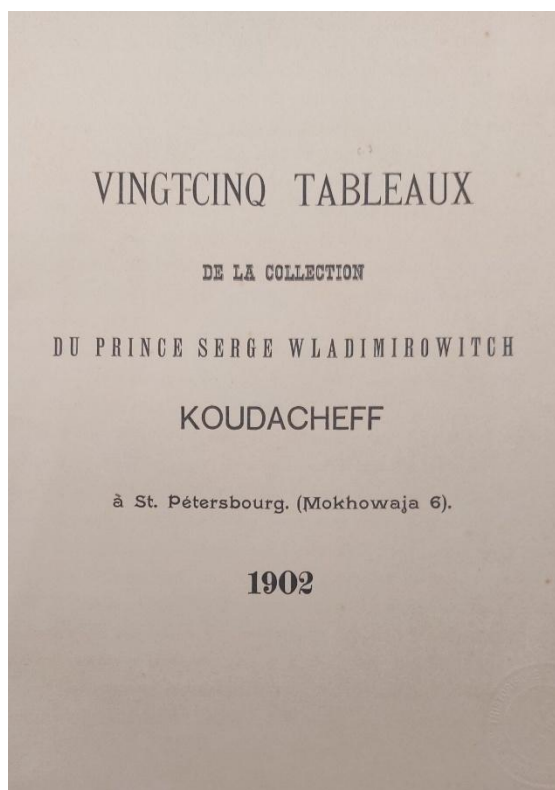
Vingt-cinq tableaux de la collection du Prince Serge Wladimirowitch Koudacheff à St. Petersburg (Mokhowaja 6, St. Petersburg 1902, with illustration.

Provenance:

Collection Prince Serge Koudacheff (1863-1933), St. Petersburg, by 1902.



The Koudacheff (Kudashev) collection had been started around 1896 by the Russian prince Sergei Wladimirowitch Koudacheff (Kudashev) (1863-1933). The collection was located in the residence of prince Koudacheff in Saint Petersburg and consisted predominantly of Dutch and Flemish paintings from the 16th, 17th and 18th century besides French and Italian paintings.



In 1902 a preliminary catalogue of this collection was published with the support of art historians Wilhem von Bode (1845-1929) and Abraham Bredius (1855-1946) besides the help of Russian collector and expert Pyotr Petrovich Semenov (Semenoff) Tyan-Shansky (1827-1914).

The painting by Jan Vermeer van Haarlem was included in this catalogue as lot number 8.

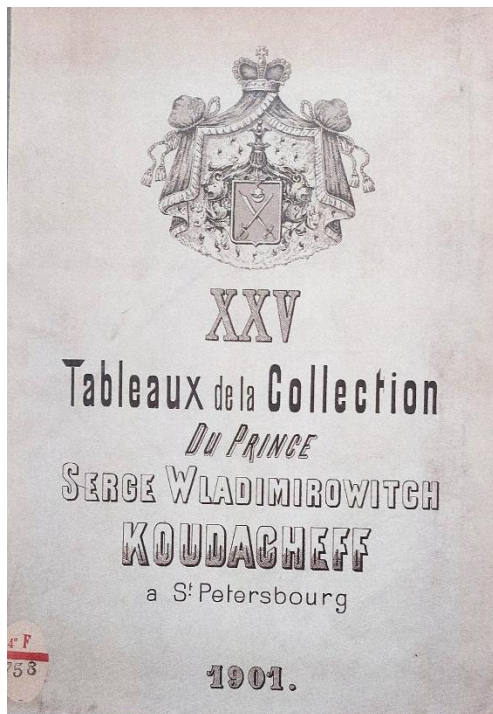
Sources

Vingt-cinq tableaux de la collection du Prince Serge Wladimirowitch Koudacheff,
Saint Petersburg, 1902

Bibliothèque Nationale de France (BNF) Gallica database

Dutch Institute of Art History (RKD)
(The Hague):

RKD database – archive number 200510851



The provisional catalogue of the Koudacheff collection was edited in French and completed between January 13th and January 28th 1902 in Saint Petersburg.

The introduction included the following text:

'La petite collection de tableaux du Prince Koudacheff est une de celles, qui ont été formées le plus récemment à St. Pétersbourg. Commencée par son propriétaire actuel en 1896, elle continue à se compléter et présente en ce moment une réunion de près d'une centaine d'oeuvres de maîtres des XVI, XVII et XVIII Siècles, dont la plupart appartiennent aux écoles flamande et hollandaise et quelques unes aux écoles allemande et française.'

Désireux de faire connaître à nos confrères animés de la passion du collectionneur, quelques unes de nos toiles, nous nous sommes décidés à faire paraître dès maintenant plusieurs reproductions de tableaux, choisis parmi les planches, préparées en vue de la collection d'un catalogue de notre petite collection.'

Nous voulons espérer qu'on nous pardonnera cette hâte qui peut sembler tant soit peu intempestive, mais qu'au fond tout ardent amateur comprendra et excusera.

Pour ne dire qu'un mot sur l'ensemble de la collection nous nous bornerons à indiquer que le principe essentiel, qui n'a cessé de nous guider dans le choix de tableaux, a été non la recherche exclusive de grands noms, mais la parfaite conservation des toiles et la valeur propre de l'oeuvre par elle même, quelque fut l'importance de son auteur.

Si les tableaux, que nous avons réunis, devaient un jour provoquer l'intérêt des amateurs de maîtres anciens nous ne voudrions pas manquer l'occasion, qui se présente dès aujourd'hui, d'apporter l'expression de notre profonde reconnaissance à Monsieur le D-r Bode, M-r Bredius et P.P. Semenoff, connaisseurs émérites, dont l'autorité est universelle, pour l'aimable concours et les précieux conseils qu'il n'ont pas refusé au collectionneur débutant.'

S. Pétersbourg, le 13/28 Janvier 1902

Observations

The introduction includes some interesting clues which are of significant importance in view of further provenance research:

- the painting by Jan Vermeer van Haarlem I was part of the collection in 1902 and included in the catalogue; thus it can be concluded that Koudacheff must have acquired the painting between 1896 and (the start of) 1902; this fact provides a starting point for specific research related to auction catalogues (in case he acquired the painting via public auction) or exhibition catalogues (in case he acquired the painting via an art dealer) published between 1896 and 1901;
- the catalogue was set up with the help of art historians Wilhelm von Bode and Abraham Bredius besides the support of expert and collector Pyotr Petrovich Semenov (Semenoff) Tyan-Shansky; this fact provides a starting point for specific research related to the personal archives of Von Bode, Bredius and Semenov besides other potential sources

Photo and catalogue description (right):

*Collection du Prince Serge Koudacheff à St.
Pétersbourg*
Jan van der Meer (v. Haarlem) (1628-1691)
Paysage (0,55 x 0,44)

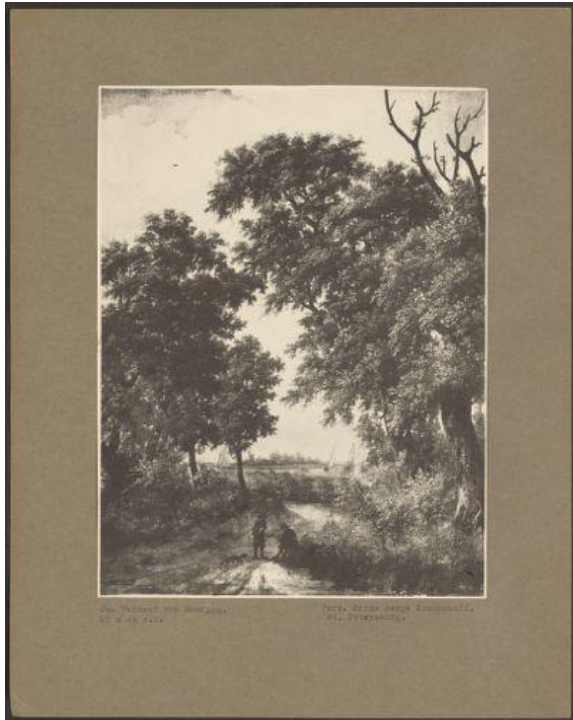


Photo and catalogue description (left):

RKD database – folder 24513

Provenance Phase 2 (1905 and onwards)

The Koudacheff (Kudashev) collection was sold between 1905 and 1909 at the occasion of 4 auctions held in Berlin (1905), Amsterdam (1905), London (1906) and in Amsterdam (1909).

Auction February 14th 1905 in Berlin

The auction in Berlin included 155 paintings, 13 of which originated from the Koudacheff collection. The Dutch art historian Cornelis Hofstede de Groot attended this auction in person.

The painting by Jan Vermeer van Haarlem was not included in this particular auction.

Auction catalogue

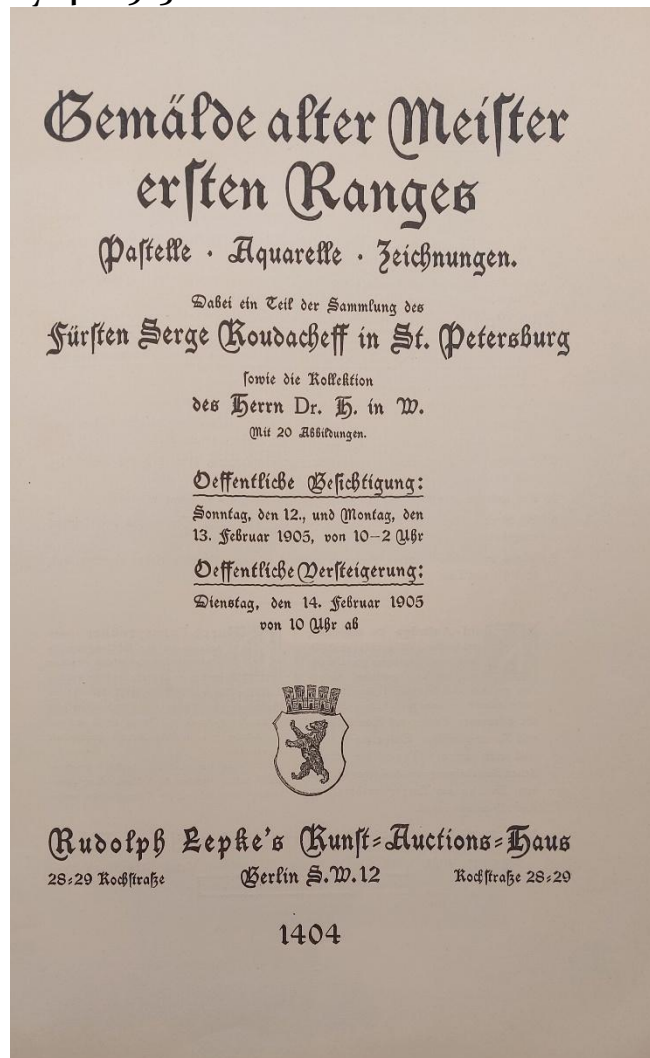
Oelgemaelde alter Meister ersten Ranges, Versteigerung Dienstag, den 14. Februar 1905, Rudolph Lepke's Kunst Auctions-Haus, Berlin

Auction title

Gemälde alter Meister ersten Ranges – Dabei ein Teil der Sammlung des Fürsten Serge Koudacheff in St. Petersburg

Location and date auction

Berlin, February 14th 1905



Sources

Lugt reference number: 62962 (Répertoire des Catalogues de Ventes Publiques – Quatrième Période 1901-1925, Fondation Custodia / Frits Lugt, Paris, 1987)

RKD – Dutch Institute of Art History (The Hague):

RKD archive numbers: 201011250; 201204421; 201204422; 202502570

Auction June 27th 1905 in Amsterdam

The auction in Amsterdam was entirely dedicated to the Koudacheff collection and included 32 paintings.

This auction was also attended by the Dutch art historian Cornelis Hofstede de Groot.

The painting by Jan Vermeer van Haarlem was included in this auction as lot number 19.

Auction catalogue

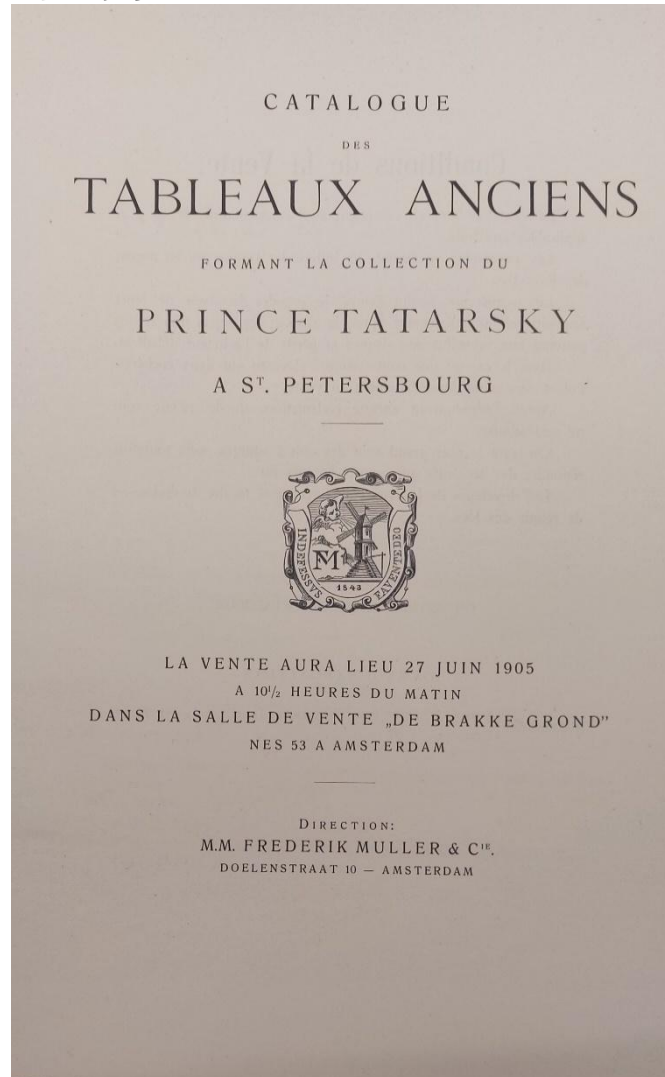
Collection – Tatarsky Tableaux Anciens
Vente le 27 juin 1905 chez Frederik Muller & Cie.

Auction title

Catalogue des Tableaux Anciens
formant la collection du Prince Tatarsky
à St. Petersburg, Vente le 27 juin 1905
chez Frederik Muller & Cie.

Location and date auction

Amsterdam, June 27th 1905



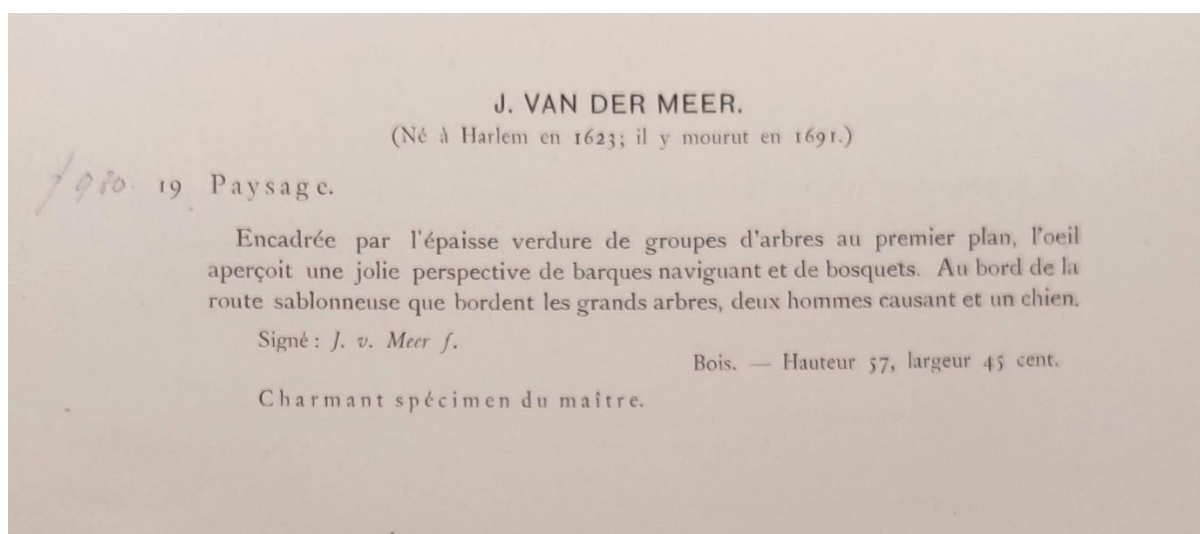
Sources

Lugt reference number: 63555 (Répertoire des Catalogues de Ventes Publiques – Quatrième Période 1901-1925, Fondation Custodia / Frits Lugt, Paris, 1987);

RKD – Dutch Institute of Art History (The Hague):

RKD archive numbers: 20070836; 200813431; 201402922; 201405569; 202500157

Auction June 27th 1905 in Amsterdam – Description lot number 19



J. van der Meer (Né à Harlem en 1623; il y mourut en 1691)

19. *Paysage. Encadrée par l'épaisse verdure de groupes d'arbres au premier plan, l'oeil aperçoit une jolie perspective de barques naviguant et de bosquets. Au bord de la route sablonneuse que bordent les grands arbres, deux hommes causant et un chien.*

Signé: J. v. Meer f. – Bois. – Hauteur 57, largeur 45 cent.

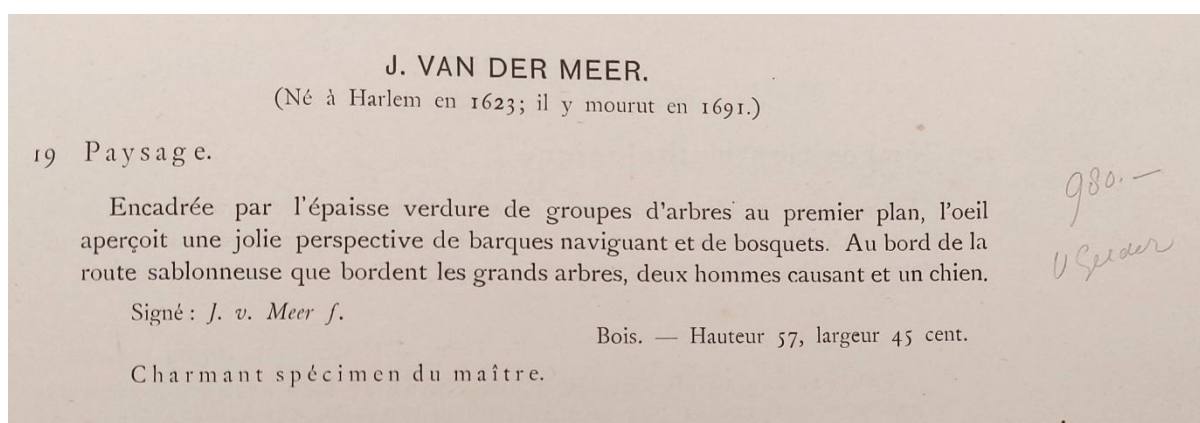
Charmant spécimen du maître

Observations

In 1905 the dimensions of the painting (panel) were indicated as 57 x 45 CM whereas the current dimensions are 55 x 45 CM.

The 1905 description mentions the signature *J. v. Meer* with the addition *f* which almost certainly stands for *fecit* or *made/created by*.

Auction June 27th 1905 in Amsterdam – Annotation lot number 19



Annotation: 980,- V. Gelder

Observations

The amount of Hfl. 980,- (Dutch guilder) is probably the hammer price for which the painting was bought at the auction in 1905 in Amsterdam by bidder/buyer Van Gelder.

Auction December 1st 1906 in London

The sub section of the auction dedicated to the Koudacheff collection held in London included 21 paintings and were presented as the property of princess Vera Koudacheff, the first wife of collector prince Sergei Koudacheff.

This auction was also attended by the Dutch art historian Cornelis Hofstede de Groot

Auction catalogue

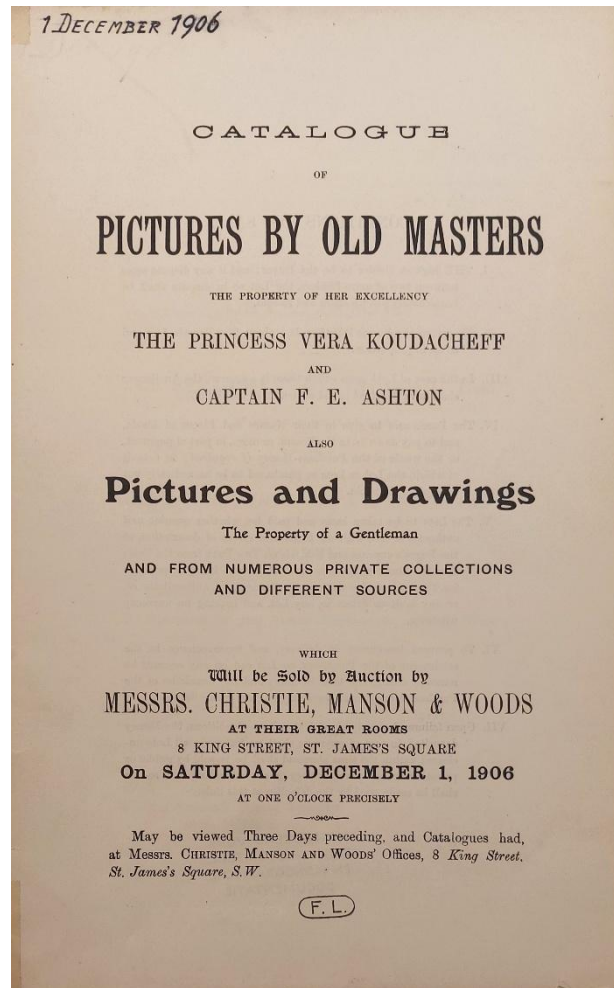
Catalogus of Pictures by Old Masters – the property of her excellency The Princess Vera Koudacheff and Captain F.E. Ahston also Pictures and Drawings – the property of a gentleman and from numerous private collections and different sources. Christie, Manson & Woods, December 1st 1906.

Auction title

The following are the Property of Her Excellency the Princess Vera Koudacheff (sub-section catalogue)

Location and date auction

London, December 1st 1906

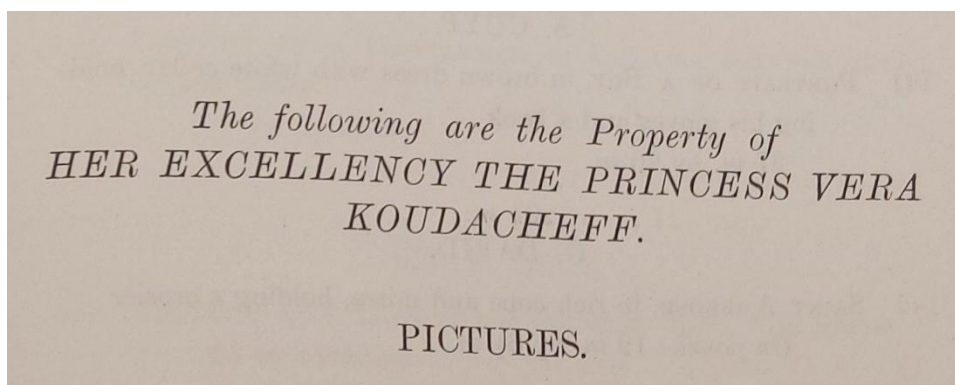


Sources

Lugt reference number: 64859 (Répertoire des Catalogues de Ventes Publiques – Quatrième Période 1901-1925, Fondation Custodia / Frits Lugt, Paris, 1987);

RKD – Dutch Institute for Art History (The Hague)

RKD archive numbers: 201301038; 201308030; 201308031



Auction April 27th 1909 in Amsterdam

The sub section of the auction dedicated to the Koudacheff collection held in Amsterdam included 25 paintings.

This auction was also attended by the Dutch art historian Cornelis Hofstede de Groot

Auction catalogue

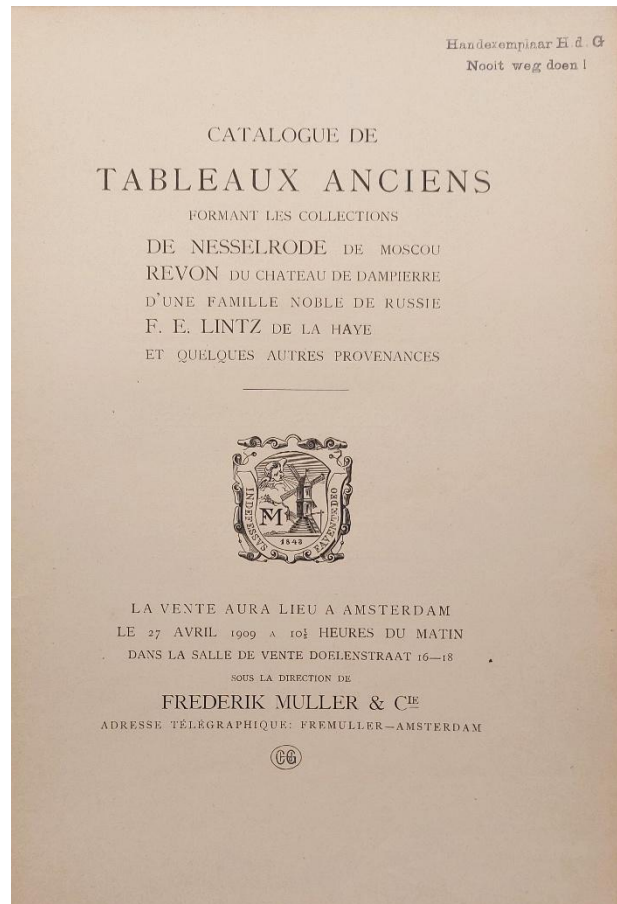
Catalogue de Tableaux Anciens formant les collections De Nesselrode de Moscou, Revon du Château de Dampierre, d'une famille noble de Russie, F.E. Lintz de la Haye et quelques autres provenances.

Auction title

Tableaux provenant de la collection du Prince K....F de St. Petersbourg.
(sub-section catalogue)

Location and date auction

Amsterdam, April 27th 1909

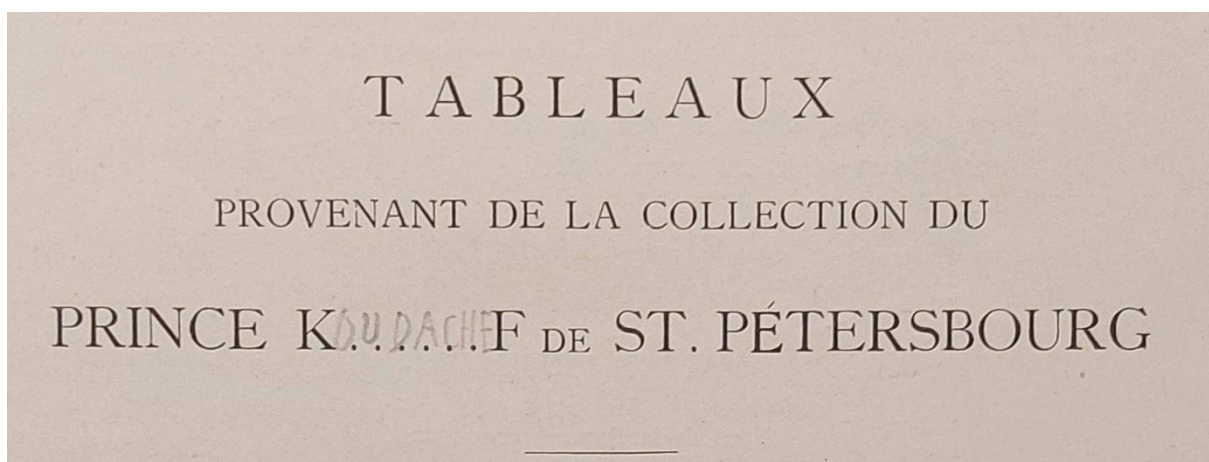


Sources

Lugt reference number: 67499 (Répertoire des Catalogues de Ventes Publiques – Quatrième Période 1901-1925, Fondation Custodia / Frits Lugt, Paris, 1987);

RKD – Dutch Institute for Art History (The Hague):

RKD archive numbers: 200708536; 200813431; 201402922; 201405569; 202500157



Koudacheff (Kudashev) family – background information

Prince Sergei Vladimirovitch Koudacheff (Kudashev) was born on December 14th 1863 in Kiev (formerly Russia, nowadays Ukraine) and died on February 28th 1933 in Florence (Italy).

Family

Prince Sergei Vladimirowitch Koudacheff belonged to a prominent noble family of originally Tatar descent, who had acquired the right to bear a princely title within the Russian Empire since the 17th century. He was the son of prince Vladimir Sergejewitch Koudacheff (1833-1871) and princess Olga Nikolaevna Horvath (1840-1907).

Professional career

Prince Sergei Vladimirowitch Koudacheff held two consecutive representative positions at the imperial Russian court under the reign of tsar Nicholas II.

During the first years of his court career, he held the ceremonial rank of gentleman of the bedchamber (Kamer-Yunker); later, he was promoted to the higher rank of chamberlain (Kamerger). This was a prestigious title at the imperial court awarded to high-ranking noblemen, which carried the official administrative rank of actual state councillor (a high civilian rank within the Russian table of ranks).

His positions were primarily intended for ceremonial duties at the imperial court, including state receptions and accompanying the imperial family on official occasions. The positions he held were part of the directorate-general or main department of Apanages.

This was the specific government body responsible for managing the personal wealth, estates, and private property of the Russian imperial family, operating as an independent unit within the Ministry of the Imperial Court.

The 4 core tasks of this part of the imperial government apparatus consisted of:

- property management: supervising the 'apanage estates' (these were vast areas, forests, and agricultural lands specifically designated to generate income for the grand dukes, grand duchesses, and other members of the House of Romanov;
- peasant administration: until the emancipation reforms of the 1860s (under Tsar Alexander II), the directorate administered millions of 'apanage peasants' who lived and worked on these royal lands, collecting taxes and managing their agricultural production;
- financial management: the revenues generated by this department directly funded the allowances, stipends, pensions, and dowries of the extended imperial family;
- development of estates and enterprises: financing and managing the construction, maintenance, and economic development of various royal residences, industrial enterprises (such as wineries and factories), and agricultural activities throughout the empire (such as the imperial estate in Livadia in the Crimea).

In addition to his duties at the imperial court, prince Sergei Vladimirowitch Koudacheff was reportedly also a member of the board of directors of several companies. For instance, he sat on the board of directors of the Podolsk Railway Company, the Russian Commercial and Industrial Bank, and the Salamandra Fire Insurance Company.

This photograph of prince Koudacheff was taken on the occasion of the Romanov costume ball on February 11 and 13, 1903, at the Winter Palace in Saint Petersburg, commemorating the 290th anniversary of the Romanov reign.

Diplomatic careers Koudacheff family members

Several members of the Koudacheff family held high diplomatic positions and represented the Imperial Government of Russia during the reign of tsar Nicholas II (1868–1918, tsar of Russia from 1894 to 1917).

Prince Nikolai Alexandrowitch Koudacheff (1868–1921) was a cousin of prince Sergei Vladimirowitch Koudacheff and built a career as a diplomat. He served as first secretary at the Russian embassies in Tokyo (1902) and Constantinople (1906).

In 1905, he was part of the Russian delegation at the Portsmouth peace conference, which ended the Russo-Japanese War (1904–1905).

Between 1910 and 1913, he worked as Russia's chargé d'affaires in Washington, and in 1916, he was appointed envoy extraordinary and minister plenipotentiary to China until he had to step down in 1920 after China severed ties with the former tsarist regime.



His older brother, prince Ivan Alexandrowitch Koudacheff (1859–1933), was also active in the diplomatic service. From 1906 to 1910, he was the envoy to Denmark, from 1910 to 1916, he held this position in Belgium and Luxembourg, and until the revolution in 1917, he served as ambassador to Spain.



Private life

Prince Sergei Vladimirowitch Koudacheff married countess Vera Maximilianovna von Nieroth (1874–1920) in 1894, with whom he had two children. The eldest child was their daughter, Myra or Maria Sergueievna Koudacheff (1895–1990). The youngest child was their son, Serge Sergeievich Koudacheff (1901–1991).

Vera Maximilianovna von Nieroth was the daughter of count Maximilian Carl Benedikt von Nieroth (1846–1914), an imperial chamberlain and master of the hunt of Baltic-German descent, and Anastasia Feodorovna Trepova (1849–1940), a former maid of honour in service of tsarina Maria Feodorovna (1847–1928), the wife of tsar Alexander III (1845–1894).

Before marrying, countess Vera Maximilianovna von Nieroth served as a maid of honour to tsarina Alexandra Feodorovna (1872–1918), the wife of tsar Nicholas II.

The photographs of princess Koudacheff were also taken on the occasion of the Romanov costume ball on February 11 and 13, 1903, at the Winter Palace in Saint Petersburg, commemorating the 290th anniversary of the Romanov reign.

290th anniversary Romanov reign

In 1903, a grand masquerade ball was organized to mark the 290th anniversary of the Romanov rule in Russia, which began in 1603.

The event took place over two days, on February 11 and 13, 1903, and was held at the Winter Palace in St. Petersburg. Tsar Nicholas II and Tsarina Alexandra Feodorovna invited 390 guests to the anniversary celebration and the subsequent masquerade ball.

These included members of the extended imperial family, Russian nobility, and court officials—among them Prince Sergei Vladimirovich Kudashev and his wife Vera—as well as a select number of foreign dignitaries.

The masked ball was themed around the 17th century, and all the guests participated in specially designed historical costumes.



group photo of participants in costume at the Romanov Ball, Saint Petersburg, 1903

Flight and exile in Sweden

Due to his position and as a member of the Russian nobility, prince Sergei Vladimirovitch Koudacheff was in immediate mortal danger right after the outbreak of the revolution in February 1917 in St. Petersburg.

With the help of the then 2nd secretary of the American embassy, Norman Armour, prince Koudacheff, along with his wife Vera and their children Myra and Serge, managed to escape using false papers and fled to the nearby border with Finland.

Presumably, like many other refugees, they crossed the frozen Lake Ladoga or the Gulf of Finland on foot during the winter to bypass border controls. Finland had declared its independence from Russia in 1917, making the country a relatively safe destination for refugees from Russia. Via Finland, the Koudacheff family eventually arrived in Sweden in the spring of 1917.

Initially, they stayed at the Grand Hôtel in the Swedish capital of Stockholm, but later moved to a luxurious villa in the fashionable seaside resort of Saltsjöbaden, in the immediate vicinity of Stockholm.

The Koudacheff family took up residence in Villa Skärtofta and would presumably remain there until the middle or end of 1918.



Grand Hotel, Stockholm

This villa in Saltsjöbaden also became a gathering place for wealthy Russian refugees – mostly of noble descent – where prince Koudacheff regularly organized parties and gatherings.



Villa Skärtofta in Saltsjöbaden, Sweden

In newspaper articles from the autumn of 1918, the villa and Prince Koudacheff were linked to a potential temporary place of exile for the German Emperor Wilhelm II (1859–1941), who had been deposed in early 1918.

It was in this setting that their daughter Myra came into contact with the Danish explorer and archaeologist Frans Blom (1893–1963) in the summer of 1918. He proposed to her, but she turned him down, only to get engaged to the American Norman Armour a short time later.

Marriage of Myra Koudacheff and Norman Armour

In his capacity as 2nd secretary of the American embassy in St. Petersburg, Norman Armour (1887–1982) had helped the Koudacheff family escape from Russia. The future United States ambassador to Canada, Haiti, Chile, Argentina, Spain, Venezuela, and Guatemala had been stationed in St. Petersburg since 1916 and witnessed the Russian Revolution firsthand.

During the 1917–1918 period, he was responsible on behalf of the embassy for documenting the political developments taking place in Russia and keeping the American government informed.

Following the first revolution in February 1917 and the provisional government led by Prime Minister Georgy Lvov (1861–1925) and later Alexander Kerensky (1881–1970), he witnessed the second revolution in October 1917, in which the Bolsheviks, led by Vladimir Lenin (1870–1924), seized power.



Norman Armour

From the beginning of the Allied intervention in Russia in March 1918, all foreign diplomats were in immediate danger, and from the summer of that year, they became targets themselves of the revolutionary Russian army. In July 1918, the American embassy staff was ordered to leave Saint Petersburg and evacuate to Vologda, a city over 500 kilometers east of St. Petersburg that was considered safer.



Princess Myra Koudacheff

The assassination attempt on Lenin on August 30, 1918, was the starting signal for the Red Terror, the bloodiest phase of the Russian Revolution, during which the Bolsheviks began arresting foreign diplomats on suspicion of espionage and conspiracy with counter-revolutionary groups.

Norman Armour was arrested by the Bolsheviks in late August, taken to Moscow, and detained for a month due to his involvement in the escape of the Koudacheff family in 1917.

He managed to escape and fled Russia using false papers via Finland to Sweden, where he arrived in November 1918. Once he arrived in Sweden, he joined the family of prince Sergei Vladimirowitch Koudacheff and became engaged to their daughter Myra Koudacheff that same month.

In February 1919, the couple married in Stockholm, and she would accompany him all over the world throughout his entire diplomatic career.

Norman Armour and Myra Koudacheff had a son together, Norman Armour Junior (1920–1978), who was born in Brussels in 1920 and—like his father—would later join the United States Department of State.

Exile in Paris

It is not entirely clear when Prince Sergei Vladimirovich Koudacheff, his wife, and their son Serge left Sweden after their daughter married Norman Armour. It is assumed that they arrived in France sometime in 1919 and stayed—at least temporarily—in Paris.

According to a notarial deed dated 29 October 1926, Prince Sergei Vladimirowitch Koudacheff purchased a property located at 2 Rue Montaigne in the chic 8th arrondissement of Paris in December 1919.

He used this location as a residence (whether temporary or otherwise) and as the official registered office of a public limited company under the name S.A. (Société Anonyme) Elysée Bellevue Hôtel.

The company focused on the subletting and operation of the hotel of the same name, Elysée Bellevue Hôtel, and the hospitality establishment Café du Cirque – Gauffres des Champs-Elysées, located at 1 Avenue Matignon and 2 Rond-Point des Champs-Elysées in the French capital.

According to the notarial deed, his fellow partners were his son Serge, his nephew Count Michael Fyodorowitch von Nieroth (1899–1994) (son of his brother-in-law Count Fyodor Maksimilianowitch von Nieroth (1871–1952)), and Viktor Petrowitch Taranovsky (1864–1937), a former major general in the tsarist army.

According to a supplementary notarial deed dated 27 July 1927, Prince Sergei Vladimirowitch Koudacheff – as the principal owner – entered into a lease agreement for the operation of the hotel and restaurant, effective from 1 July 1927 and running for a term of nearly 25 years, until 1 April 1951.

Apart from any other financial resources available to him after fleeing Russia, this business arrangement was intended to provide him with long-term financial security.

Almost immediately after the purchase of the property on Rue Montaigne and the establishment of the company, his wife Vera died in February 1920. She was buried in the Père-Lachaise Cemetery in Paris, where her mother, her son Serge, and other family members were later also laid to rest in the family grave.

Second marriage prince Sergei Vladimirowitch Koudacheff

Following the death of his first wife, prince Sergei Vladimirowitch Koudacheff remarried in Paris in 1922, wedding countess Olga Erikovna von Kreutz von Pistohlkors (1888–1963). Given the connections both had with the imperial court in Russia before the revolution, it is possible and even likely that they already knew each other or that they had met within the circles of Russian aristocratic émigrés in the French capital.

Her father was Major General Erich Gerhard von Pistohlkors (1853–1935), who married her mother, Olga Valerianovna Karnovich (1865–1929), in 1884. During her marriage, she began an affair with Grand Duke Paul Alexandrowitch Romanov (1860–1919), the uncle of Tsar Nicholas II. Due to the affair, the Von Pistohlkors couple divorced in 1901.

In 1902, she married Grand Duke Paul Alexandrowitch in secret in Italy, causing a massive scandal at the Russian court. This morganatic marriage (a legal marriage within the nobility or royal houses where one partner is of significantly lower social standing) was strictly forbidden by tsar Nicholas II.

As a punishment, Grand Duke Paul Alexandrowitch was banished from Russia, and his assets were frozen. The couple settled in Paris and were only granted permission to return to Russia in 1915. Olga subsequently received the title of princess Paley from the tsar.

During the revolution, princess Paley—the mother of prince Koudacheff's second wife—fled to Paris with her daughters and initially settled in the luxurious residence she had purchased at the time with her husband, Grand Duke Paul Alexandrowitch Romanov. In the early 1920s, this residence formed a gathering and meeting place for Russian émigrés of aristocratic descent.



Countess Olga Erikovna von Kreutz von Pistohlkors (far right, circa 1912)

Exile in Florence

When the Koudacheff couple left Paris and where his son Serge settled remains unclear for the time being, but eventually Prince Sergei Vladimirovitch Koudacheff and his second wife moved to Florence, which was home to a relatively large community of Russian émigrés.

The notarial deed from 1926 reveals that his permanent address that year was Via Stiberti No. 12 in Florence, located in the upscale Montughi district and close to the Stibbert Museum, which houses the art collection of the English collector Frederick Stibbert (1838–1906).

From his marriage to Olga Erikovna von Kreutz von Pistohlkors, a daughter was born in Florence: princess Olga Sergueievna Koudacheff (Pela) (1926–1963).



Stibbert Museum Florence

The influx of Russian émigrés to Florence formed a remarkable chapter in the city's history. Although cities like Paris and Berlin accommodated much larger groups of refugees, Florence specifically attracted the wealthier Russian nobility, artists, and intellectuals. Indeed, many of them had already visited the city before the revolution as a holiday destination or a spa resort. Unlike the 19th-century Russian elite who travelled to Tuscany, most émigrés after 1917 often arrived destitute. Their possessions and bank accounts in Russia had been frozen or confiscated by the Bolsheviks. Out of necessity, they had to start providing for their own livelihood in Italy. In Florence, the émigrés formed a tight-knit network.

Prince Sergei Vladimirovich Koudacheff died there in 1933 and was buried at the Cimitero Evangelico Allori di Firenze in Florence. His second wife, Olga Erikovna von Kreutz von Pistohlkors, died thirty years later, in 1963.

Koudacheff city palace in Saint Petersburg

As an art collector of (mainly) Dutch and Flemish paintings from the 16th to the 18th century, he owned a collection of paintings in Saint Petersburg, located in a city palace at 6 Mokhovaya Street. Mokhovaya Street is situated in the historical heart of Saint Petersburg.

In the 19th and early 20th centuries, it was one of the most prestigious streets for the aristocracy and intellectuals.

Grand city palaces and townhouses stood side by side here. Renowned writers, composers, and statesmen lived in the immediate vicinity.

The palace of prince Sergei Vladimirowitch Koudacheff was at the time arranged as a private museum for his painting collection. The building survived the revolution and the Second World War and still forms part of the protected architectural heritage in the center of Saint Petersburg.

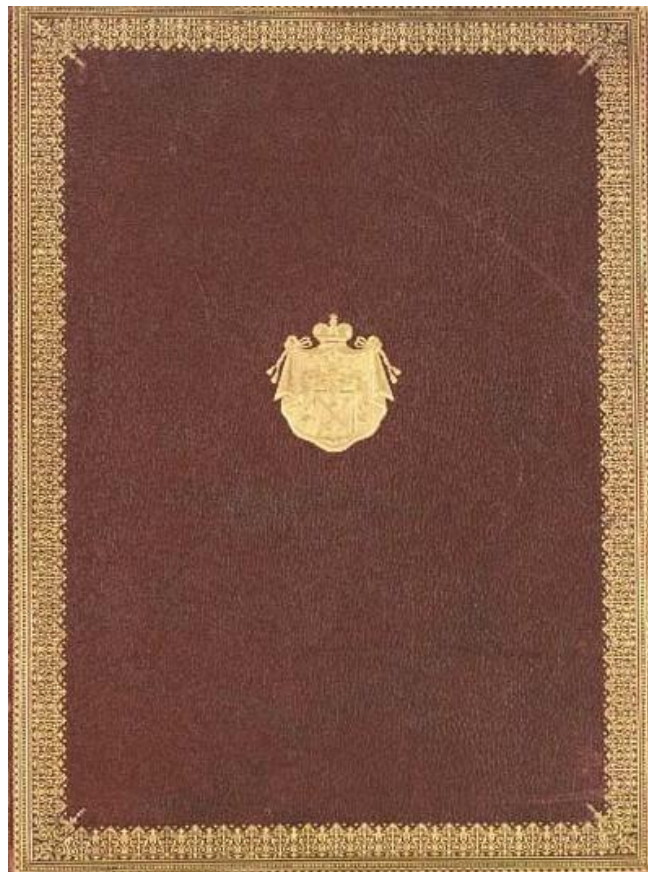


Dismantling painting collection

Much of the information about the collection is thanks to the catalogue *Vingt-cinq Tableaux de la Collection du Prince Serge Wladimirowitch Koudacheff*, published in 1902 in Saint Petersburg. The catalogue was luxuriously produced as a large-format album bound in brown morocco leather with gold embossing and featured the coat of arms of the Koudacheff family.

The catalogue contained photographic plates of the 25 absolute masterpieces in his possession. At the time, it likely served not only as a status symbol but perhaps also as an early sales brochure for international art dealers.

Although he was known as a great art collector, it turned out that he had already liquidated his collection long before the Russian Revolution through 4 different auctions held between 1905 and 1909 in Berlin, Amsterdam, and London.



In total, 91 paintings from the Koudacheff collection were auctioned between 1905 and 1909 (13 during the auction in Berlin in 1905, 32 during the auction in Amsterdam in 1905, 21 during the auction in London in 1906, and 25 during the auction in Amsterdam in 1909). Whether the entire collection was auctioned this way or if prince Sergei Vladimirowitch Koudacheff retained other paintings in his possession after 1909 remains unclear.

The reason for the disposal of the painting collection remains unclear to this day. As far as is known, no letters or diaries are available from which his exact personal motives can be deduced. One of the reasons may have been related to the political situation in Russia at the beginning of the 20th century. The period between 1900 and 1905 was an extremely turbulent time. Discontent among the population grew, strikes increased, and the threat of a revolution – which ultimately broke out on a large scale for the first time in 1905 – was in the air.

Many far-sighted members of the noble elite understood that physical wealth in Saint Petersburg was no longer secure. By drawing attention to his collection through the internationally distributed catalogue of 1902, prince Koudacheff would have been able to convert his capital into liquid assets in a timely manner and largely secure them in foreign accounts.

Another hypothesis for the dismantling of the painting collection could be based on the assumption that financial difficulties – whether temporary or permanent – were the primary motivation. It can be assumed that the cost of living, maintaining a city palace, and the expenses generally associated with participating in the life of the social elite to which prince Koudacheff and his family belonged must have been considerable.

This is evident, among other things, from the fact that immediately after fleeing Russia, he was able to rent or purchase the luxury villa in Saltsjöbaden, or finance the purchase of his residence in Paris and the establishment of his company.

Another – also hypothetical – assumption is that the timing of the publication of the 1902 catalogue did not entirely coincidentally coincide with the hype surrounding Dutch and Flemish masters around the turn of the century and the years that followed. Driven in part by extremely wealthy American collectors, the international demand for paintings of Dutch and Flemish origin from the 16th and 17th centuries in particular increased enormously and led to record prices. This period was therefore ideally suited to sell such paintings, which could explain why prince Koudacheff disposed of his collection relatively quickly during this exact timeframe, after having started collecting only about 10 years earlier.

Historical figures

- Prince Wladimir Sergejewitch Koudacheff (1833-1871); father of prince Sergei Wladimirowitch Koudacheff
- Princess Olga Nikolaevna Horvath (1840-1907); mother of prince Sergei Wladimirowitch Koudacheff
- Prince Ivan Aleksandrowitch Koudacheff (1859-1933); cousin of prince Sergei Wladimirowitch Koudacheff and diplomat
- Prince Nikolaj Aleksandrowitch Koudacheff (1868-1921); cousin of prince Sergei Wladimirowitch Koudacheff and diplomat
- Countess Vera Maksimilanovna von Nieroth (1874-1920); first wife of prince Sergei Wladimirowitch Koudacheff
- Princess Myra (Maria) Serguéievna Koudacheff (1895-1990); daughter of prince Sergei Wladimirowitch Koudacheff
- Prince Sergei Sergeievitch Koudacheff (1901-1991); son of prince Sergei Wladimirowitch Koudacheff
- Count Maximilian Carl Benedict von Nieroth (1846-1914); father of countess Maksimilanovna von Nieroth
- Countess Anastasia Feodorovna Trepova (1849-1940); mother of countess Maksimilanovna von Nieroth
- Count Fyodor Maksimilianowitch von Nieroth (1871-1952); brother of countess Vera Maksimilanovna von Nieroth
- Count Michael Fyodorowitch von Nieroth (1899-1944); son of count Fyodor Maksimilianowitch von Nieroth
- Countess Olga Erikovna von Kreutz von Pistohlkors (1888-1963); second wife of prince Sergei Wladimirowitch Koudacheff
- Count Erich Gerhard von Pistohlkors (1853-1935); father of countess Olga Erikovna von Kreutz von Pistohlkors
- Countess Olga Valerianovna, princess Paley (1865-1929); mother of countess Olga Erikovna von Kreutz von Pistohlkors
- Princess Olga Serguéievna Koudacheff (Pela) (1926-1963); daughter of prince Sergei Wladimirowitch Koudacheff
- Grand Duke Paul Aleksandrowitch Romanov (1860-1919); cousin of tsar Nicholas II and stepfather of countess Olga Erikovna von Kreutz von Pistohlkors
- Tsar Alexander III (1845-1894); tsar of Russia (1881-1894)
- Tsarina Maria Fjodorovna (1847-1928); wife of tsar Alexander III
- Tsar Nicholas II (1868-1918); tsar of Russia (1894-1917)
- Tsarina Alexandra Fjodorovna (1872-1918); wife of tsar Nicholas II
- Norman Armour (1887-1982); husband of princess Myra (Maria) Serguéievna Koudacheff and son-in-law of prince Sergei Wladimirowitch Koudacheff
- Norman Armour Junior (1920-1978); son of Norman Armour and princess Myra (Maria) Serguéievna Koudacheff
- Frans Blom (1893-1963); explorer and archaeologist
- Viktor Petrowitch Taranovsky (1864-1937); major-general and business partner of prince Sergei Wladimirowitch Koudacheff

Sources & literature (provisional list) I (arranged chronologically)

Prins Sergei Wladimirowitch Koudacheff & family

- Papers relating to the foreign relations of the US, Russia 1918, Vol I, II & III; Office of the Historian, Department of State, Washington, 1918;
 - Newspaper article October 14 1918, L'Express du Midi, 1918;
 - Newspaper article October 17 1918, Le Journal du Peuple, 1918;
 - Newspaper article November 5 1918, The New York Times, New York, 1918;
 - Newspaper article February 4 1919, The Washington Herald, Washington, 1919;
 - The Emperor Nicholas II as I knew him; Major-General Sir John Hanbury-Williams, London, 1922;
 - Memories of Russia 1916-1919; Princes Olga Paley, Paris, 1924;
 - Les annonces parisiennes – Journal officiel d'annonces judiciaires et légales, le 29 octobre 1926; Bibliothèque Nationale de France (BNF) – Gallica database; 1926;
 - Les annonces parisiennes – Journal officiel d'annonces judiciaires et légales, le 27 juillet 1927; Bibliothèque Nationale de France (BNF) – Gallica database; 1927;
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 - The Koudachev Family – A princely family of the Russian Empire – Revision 1.0; Théo Armour, Mill Valley (California), 11 September 2000;
 - Restless Blood – Frans Blom, Explorer and Maya Archeologist; Tore Leifer, Jesper Nielsen & Toke Sellner Reunert, Copenhagen, 2002/2017;
 - Caught in the Revolution, Petrograd 1917 – Witnesses to the Fall of Imperial Russia; Helen Rappaport, New York, 2017;
 - PJRC update – number 13, pp. 14-18, spring 2021; Petro Jacyk Central and East European Resource Centre (PJRC) University of Toronto Libraries, Toronto, 2021;
 - After the Romanovs – Russian Exiles in Paris from the Belle Epoque through revolution and war; Helen Rappaport, New York, 2022;
 - The Belle Epoque Life in Paris of Olga Paley and Paul of Russia; Wilfred Zeisler, New York, 2025;
 - Correspondence with Théo Armour (great-grandson of prince Sergei Wladimirowitch Koudacheff); 2026;
 - Koudacheff family archive - Théo Armour; 2026
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- Archives City of Stockholm (Riksarkivet)
 - Archives City of Nacka (Saltsjöbaden)
 - Archives City of Paris (Archives de Paris)
 - Archives Cathedral Saint-Alexandre Nevsky Paris (Cathédrale Saint-Alexandre Nevski)
 - Archives Cemetery Père-Lachaise Parijs (Cimétière Père-Lachaise)
 - Archives City of Florence (Archivio di Stato di Firenze)
 - Archives Evangelical Cemetery Florence (Cimitero Evangelico Allori di Firenze)
 - Archives Russian Orthodox Church of Florence (Chiesa Russa Ortodossa della Natività)
 - Archives Russian History Museum Jourdanville, New York

Sources & literature (provisional list) II (arranged chronologically)

Provenance research painting Jan Vermeer van Haarlem I

- Exhibition and auction catalogues Galerie Georges Petit (1890-1901)
RKD – Dutch Institute for Art History (The Hague);
- Exhibition and auction catalogues Charles Sedelmeyer (1890-1901)
RKD – Dutch Institute for Art History (The Hague);
- Exhibition and auction catalogues François Kleinberger (1890-1901)
RKD – Dutch Institute for Art History (The Hague);
- Les ventes de tableaux, dessins et objets d'art au XIXe siècle (1800-1895); Louis Soulié; Paris; 1896;
- Vingt-cinq tableaux de la collection du Prince Serge Wladimirowitch Koudacheff à St. Petersburg, Mokhowaja 6, St. Petersburg 1902;
- Etudes sur les peintres des écoles hollandaise, flamande et néerlandaise qu'on trouve dans la collection Semenov et les autres collections publiques et privées de St. Pétersbourg, Sint Petersburg, 1906 - RKD archive numbers: 200301891; 200301104;
- Archive Machiel (Michel) & Irma van Gelder (The Michel and Irma van Gelder Papers) (1929) Wildenstein Plattner Institute – New York;
- Archive Cornelis Hofstede de Groot (1930) – RKD NL-HaRKD-0356
RKD – Dutch Institute for Art History (The Hague);
- Archive Abraham Bredius (1946) – RKD NL-HaRKD-0380
RKD – Dutch Institute for Art History (The Hague);
- Répertoire des Catalogues de Ventes Publiques – Troisième Période 1861-1900, Fondation Custodia / Frits Lugt, The Hague, 1964;
- Répertoire des Catalogues de Ventes Publiques – Quatrième Période 1901-1925, Fondation Custodia / Frits Lugt, Paris, 1987;
- The Russian Passion for Dutch Painting in the Golden Age – The Collection of Pyotr Semenov and the Art Market in St. Petersburg 1860-1910; Irina Sokolova, Leiden, 2015 - RKD archive number: 201509828;

Provenance Phase 3 (prior to 1902)

The provenance research related to the period prior to 1902 will focus on the sources mentioned below:

- the Koudacheff family archive, currently in the possession of Théo Armour, the great-grandson of prince Sergei Wladimirowitch Koudacheff;
- the archive of Dutch art historian Abraham Bredius who reviewed the Koudacheff collection in person in Saint Petersburg and who was involved in the creation of the collection catalogue in 1901/1902;
- the archive of Dutch art historian Cornelis Hofstede de Groot who reviewed the Koudacheff collection in person in Saint Petersburg and who included various paintings in his overall catalogue raisonné covering the most prominent Dutch painters of the 17th century;
- the exhibition and auction catalogues of French art dealer Georges Petit between 1890 and 1901 (in view of the fact that a painting by Jan van Goyen in the Koudacheff collection originated from the collection of French collector Gustave Rothan and was sold by Petit);
- the exhibition and auction catalogues of Austrian-French art dealer Charles Sedelmeyer between 1890 and 1901 (together with Petit and Kleinberger the most important dealer in Dutch and Flemish old masters at the end of the 19th and the start of the 20th century);
- the exhibition and auction catalogues of Hungarian art dealer François Kleinberger between 1890 and 1901 (together with Petit and Sedelmeyer the most important dealer in Dutch and Flemish old masters at the end of the 19th and the start of the 20th century)

Provenance Phase 4 (after 1905)

The provenance research related to the period after 1905 will focus on the sources mentioned below:

- the archive of the Dutch art dealer Machiel (Michiel) van Gelder (1864-1929) – The Michel and Irma van Gelder Papers (1898-1971), in view of the possibility that he may have been the bidder/buyer of the painting by Jan Vermeer van Haarlem I at the occasion of the auction of the Koudacheff collection in 1905 in Amsterdam